

To what extent does the portrayal of female models in heroine films, such as *Mulan*, restrict young females from venturing beyond the male gaze?

As a distinct activity with little or no hierarchies associated, media literacy guides us out of the cage of printed and written word conceptual literacy. Learning to read and write empowers the general public to interact, criticise, and comprehend society effectively. Film literacy, as a subset of media literacy, is almost certain to do the same. This essay explores how film can help to reconstruct the previously confined definition of literacy, automatically and straightforwardly conferred through uncomplicated ways of spreading knowledge.

Meanwhile, encourage young people worldwide to participate in social events equally and simultaneously across different digital media. Without the export, I believe young people are deprived of the right to think and influence progressive change. Each phase of the absorption, selection, creation, and presentation of a film should include young people, allowing them to transform private experiences into a public conversation that might lead to a gigantic collective action of some content and form an interaction with the film. Film's multimodality can break down male gaze preconceptions by integrating senses, however current research seems to be lacking in this regard. When it comes to breaking down stereotypes and offering a platform for social engagement, the film may have the potential of altering the collective gaze of social groups.

The term "literacy" is generally understood to mean socially recognized ways of communication that are embedded in social and cultural contexts and are intrinsically linked to power and authority relationships(Lankshear & Knobel, 2004; Perry, 2012). Contexts here can be applied to specific situations, actions, and participants(Dourish, 2004). Media literacy aims to foster broader literacy, cultural experience, aesthetic appreciation, critical

understanding and creative production (Burn&Reid, 2012). Promote a more thoughtful and deliberate process of thinking. Also, empowering everyone to engage with the global media environment. Since literacy has broadly been defined as the ability to read and write, viewers who just input information without reflection and output are unable to interact with public discourse. This appears counter to the advantages of media literacy should bring to society. Numerous ostensibly feminist films with female heroes as protagonists actually embody and intensify the male gaze. It is a patriarchal society's cultural product. The term "gaze" refers to the process through which people are appraised objectively while their subjective aspects are neglected. The gazing party is vibrant, dominant, and entitled. The gazed party is accordingly waiting to be evaluated and selected. According to Oliver (2017), the male gaze is a manner of depicting and perceiving women that empowers men by simultaneously demeaning and objectifying women. Additionally, the male gaze includes portraying men in films as "omnipotent" in order to appeal to their narcissism. There seems to be little awareness of how heroine films embody this.

Through different media, the tale of Mulan, a female soldier who takes her father's place in the army, has become an international sensation. Mulan fought courageously as a male and returned home to fulfil her filial responsibilities in line with female morals. Adopting her as a female role model who is "as excellent as a guy" is actually embracing patriarchal society's criteria of achievement. From 1939 to 2020, in every Mulan film, elements of a patriarchal society with murderous overtones and symbols of domination (Eisler, 1988), such as swords and helmets, have been emphasized invariably. This might reveal the fact that when a woman attempts to intervene in a social event or action, the only reference model she can choose is a man. A probable explanation is that the current female cultural pattern, which is immature and lacks pluralism, still depends on a patriarchal society's appraisal system. Female heroes

are therefore still fine-tuned and rewritten inside mature male cultural paradigms. This is a worldwide phenomenon that does not occur just in films with East Asian women as central characters. Meyers and Shevenock (2021) estimate that 47% of Marvel fans are female. Further, *Wonder Woman*, the 2017 heroine film, outperformed all male-hero films in terms of box office receipts. The Female Consciousness Awakening seems to have occurred, as women are increasingly able to observe the world of film through their own lens with satisfaction (Conaway, 2018). Nevertheless, this satisfaction is derived from a feeling of self-gender identification and pride in seeing the characters valiantly appear in armour, like a man and better than a man.

Furthermore, Edwards (1994) states that the story uses filial piety and female chastity to justify Mulan's alleged transgression. In the newest rendition, the emperor's sword award emphasises filial devotion. Mulan's story has been reinterpreted variously based on social development (Li, 2018). Media literacy should be dynamic, contingent, and debatable. It is regrettable that the attention to the family-oriented elements of femininity and the celebration of conventional feminine characteristics are still patriarchal products. For years, Disney films' primary target audience has been children aged four to twelve (O'Donnell, 2010). Numerous parents introduced their daughters to these widely known mainstream heroine films that were deemed educational. Girls are expected to be as courageous and formidable as the boys, especially to inherit the desired feminine virtues. Accordingly, the film not only reinforces patriarchal social values throughout a child's formative years but also denies the young the chance to crack the male gaze.

Even though implementing media literacy tactics is not easy, media education is a no-brainer in the educational setting since it mobilizes young people's popular cultural capital. As noted

by Mulvey(1975), the experience and the ideology we were raised in will accompany us when we enter the cinema. In conjunction with literacy's characteristics of associated with social and economic advancement(Kelder, 1996), today's global film industry desperately needs the emergence of instantaneous and contemporary feminist consciousness. This neoteric consciousness might be able to explain gender in terms of social and economic power relations (Murray, 2019). More importantly, eradicates the male gaze that has been embedded in the culture. Consequently, it is essential for young people to have the capacity to be conscious and curious when confronted with diverse information, as well as the ability to manipulate linguistic and technological resources while creating (Reia-Baptista et al., 2014). This entails not merely offering access to information to the young, but also including them in the dynamic interaction between film and audience and equipping them with sharp weapons. Literacy is contestable and contingent. Thus, it should be taught with all the disposal tools for conveying meaning. Young people should be regarded as active consumers, makers, and curators of films (Potter, 2012), rather than as payers who purchase films for the pleasure gained in the viewing experience. They might engage in a variety of ways, such as creating counter-attack clips, composing afterthoughts, or participating in discussions. As a means of boosting box office income, current heroine films are geared toward satisfying female audiences' senses of self-identity as either the same as or superior to males. Young females are unable to consider and improve their social circumstances if they are unable to interact with the film. They stay trapped by the male gaze.

However, the current study has concentrated only on the interactivity of film, as media literacy should while ignoring its multimodality nature. The following paragraph will explore whether sensory combinations are capable of evading the male gaze. The term "gaze" also refers to the process of interpretation, awareness of being seen, and the link between the

spectator and the visual media contact (Lacan, 2019; Loreck, 2016). In line with the concept of multimodality, cameras guide the audience's perception by combining background knowledge and visual perception to create a unique interpretation (Bezemer, 2012). Sophisticated filmmaking blends sensuality with intensity to give the audience a more nuanced understanding and impression of the characters. In many circumstances, the audience's interpretation validates their own "act of perception" (Metz, 1982). Films disseminate social and cultural information and foster reflection (Lord et al., 2007). The complexity of the relationships between the various meaning or semiotic systems increases proportionally with the number of modalities involved (Victoria State Government, 2019). The concept of aesthetic autonomy itself is also considered to reflect a social prejudice and a means of manifesting certain privileges (Alderson, 1997). The characteristics of women are largely ignored under the male gaze. In fact, the less aggressive and conquering nature of femininity, and the more compassionate and caring nature of others, should also be treasured gender traits. Mulan can be a female idol, but not the only model for females. Sensitive and tender women with kindness and benevolence also are.

Li(2018) holds the view that the 2009 version of the film has made some progress. For example, both the soft and pleasant Voiceover and styling contributed to the sensory effect' of Mulan's femininity. Similarly, the filmmaker aimed to portray Mulan's life-affirming pursuit of love through lines and music as she struggles with an emotional freak-out and hardships. This ingrained mindset is very difficult to change in a short time. Knowledge and literacy practice is seen as collaboratively generated by distinct social groups rather than as the result of individual perceptions (Mills, 2010). The most crucial aspect of artistic expression is that it takes place in an autonomous aesthetic realm (Alderson, 1997). The film and its possession of multimodality empower the audience with this step of understanding, enabling the autonomy

of comprehension and expression. However, there should be more awareness that Mulan's war-related depression, doubts and struggles, as well as her complicated emotions towards love, are also an instrumental part of her growth(Harris, 2011). Literary in any form is a dynamic media of deliberate communication in a variety of social and cultural contexts. According to Burn and Reidfilm(2012), film as an art form in which new genres and styles are constantly emerging may bear some responsibility. When it comes to disseminating new ideas, the film is the ideal media that blurs the line between "high art" and "popular culture" (Alderson, 1997). It is probably the most effective media for instilling an appreciation for women's capabilities and fortitude. Especially for women themselves.

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